

National Management Group Communiqué:

High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (HPAI) H7N8 in Victoria – 2025

On 8 February 2025, Agriculture Victoria confirmed a new outbreak of high pathogenicity avian influenza (HPAI) H7N8 in northern Victoria. Laboratory testing has confirmed that the HPAI H7N8 virus is genetically related to strains detected in wild birds in Australia, but different from the strains detected and eradicated in Victoria, New South Wales and the Australian Capital Territory in 2024. Additionally, this detection is unrelated to the HPAI H5 bird flu strain that has devastated poultry and wildlife populations around the world.

The National Management Group (NMG) met on 10 February 2025 and approved Victoria's initial Emergency Animal Disease Response Plan. In response to subsequent detections, the NMG reconvened on 14 March 2025 and increased the committed amount to \$37.6 million to support response activities. The NMG is comprised of all Australian governments and affected industries, including Australian Chicken Meat Federation, Australian Duck Meat Association and Australian Eggs.

In approving Victoria's Emergency Animal Disease Response Plan, the NMG established a nationally cost-shared eradication program under the Emergency Animal Disease Response Agreement. This response is being conducted by the Victorian Government in accordance with nationally agreed biosecurity response plans and procedures.

Food Standards Australia and New Zealand (FSANZ) advises that the virus is not known to transmit to humans via food and it is safe to eat properly cooked chicken meat and eggs. More information on animal diseases, human health and food safety can be found on the FSANZ: [Animal diseases, human health and food safety](#) | [Food Standards Australia New Zealand](#).

People should avoid direct contact with birds or mammals that are sick or have died unexpectedly and use good hygiene measures for handling and disposing of dead birds or mammals. In Australia there is a low risk of people becoming infected through normal contact with healthy birds.

The impressive eradication efforts in 2024 underscore the effectiveness of the national emergency animal disease response arrangements and highlights the importance of a partnership approach to biosecurity across governments, industry, community, and other stakeholders.

Reporting suspicion of exotic animal pests and diseases is easy and vital in protecting Australia. Early detection enables a rapid response and offers an improved likelihood of eradication.

If you notice any sick or dead birds, including domestic poultry, captive or wild birds, contact the Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888.